

Windows

Windows has been around from days of Windows 98 when people used to lug around laptops weighing around 4 kilos to the current crop of sleek, ultrabooks powered by Windows 8. We'll not be delving into the past and will only talk about the latest iteration of the operating system. From the get go, Windows 8 has been about Microsoft trying to get a piece of action in the mobile devices market and thus Windows 8 introduced significant changes to the platform, which were primarily focused on improving the user experience on tablets. The entire UI has been rebuilt from scratch based on the new "Modern" (previously Metro) design language. The start button and menu have been done away with and they're now replaced by a Start screen with dynamically updated tiles laid out in a grid.



Windows 8 Start Screen

Windows now places increased importance on cloud-based services, with providing out-of-the box integration with a lot of services like Windows Live, Xbox Live, Skydrive, social networks and other such online services. Microsoft also

introduced a digital distribution system geared towards touch-based applications called Windows Store (as opposed to Windows Phone Store). Apps from Windows Store run with a new set of APIs called Windows Runtime. This API supports programming languages such as C, C++, VB.NET, C# and HTML5 + JS. As mentioned earlier these are not the normal apps but are geared towards touch-based interaction and hence follow the Modern UI design language. Windows for the first time has also been made available for ARM based machines where it is called Windows RT. Windows 8 also features the much maligned Secure Boot feature from UEFI which uses a public-key infrastructure to verify the integrity of the OS and prevent unauthorized programs. The problem with this is that if a user wants to install a different OS for example, Ubuntu onto the device then they'll not be able to do so as it requires their program (bootloader) to be signed.

Windows 8 met with a lukewarm response, the new design language has faced much flack for being confusing and difficult to learn. The interface